

FACES OF PROTEST Sonam Wangchuk during his hunger strike; CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke (far right)

PTI

18, citing medical advice and high court directions, the police took Wangchuk to Safdarjung Hospital in what his wife, Gitanjali J. Angmo, called illegal detention. He was later transferred to Medanta in Gurugram after the court responded to a petition by Angmo.

The police invoked Section 163 of the BNSS (Bharatiya Nagrik Suraksha Sanhita) and refused permission for the march to Parliament. Despite rain, multi-layered barricades, 3,000 police personnel and localised internet shutdowns, tens of thousands converged, coordinating through Bluetooth mesh-messaging applications that operate without cellular networks. The CJP claimed that more than 150 protesters had been injured in police lathi-charge. Pellet guns, too, were allegedly used against the protesters. The police said 118 personnel—most of them injured in stone-pelting—and around 60 protesters were hurt. Six FIRs were registered, more than 70 people detained, and between 15 and 20 government vehicles were vandalised.

The unrest spread beyond Delhi. Mumbai Police fortified South Mumbai and registered seven FIRs against 900 people who protested at Shivaji Park. Hundreds attended vigils in Bengaluru, Goa and elsewhere. The CJP insists that their demand is about institutional accountability rather than merely the removal of one minister. "Pradhan's resignation will be the first step towards accountability," says Saurav Das, the CJP's chief spokesperson (see interview, '*We want this to remain a leaderless movement*'). "Along with that, we will place our other demands before the government. We have a detailed five-point charter for education reform. It spells out our demands for transparency, accountability and other changes."

Union health minister J.P. Nadda was tasked with opening a political channel with the protesters. On the evening of July 20, Nadda held a two-hour meeting with Das and Ashutosh Ranka. They submitted a memorandum demanding Pradhan's resignation, an end to what the CJP described as Wangchuk's hospital confinement, and compensation of Rs 1 crore each for the families of students who had died by suicide after the NEET leak. Nadda said the demands would be considered at the appropriate level and urged the protesters to end their sit-in. He later visited RML Hospital to meet injured protesters and police personnel.

On the night of July 21, Nadda and Union minister Jitendra Singh met Wangchuk in hospital and appealed to him to end his fast. According to Wangchuk, they assured him that the government would positively consider adequate compensation for the bereaved families and allow a meaningful discussion in Parliament on accountability, including the demand for the education minister's resignation. Wangchuk responded the following day in an open letter to both ministers. In it, he set one clear condition for ending his fast: an unequivocal assurance that no protester would face punitive or retaliatory legal action for participating in the agitation. The government had offered a process—discussion, consideration and assurances that the demands would be examined. The letter changed the terms of the standoff, but the streets were less relenting. Then, on July 24, Wangchuk ended his 26-day hunger strike after the Centre gave him written assurances that it would discuss the NEET-UG paper leak, examination accountability and wider reforms in Parliament.

VOX POP

"EXAMS NEED CERTAINTY"

SOMESH | 24
Teacher recruitment aspirant, Jaipur

The crisis isn't just paper leaks anymore; it's the uncertainty over whether exams will happen at all. I spent months preparing, paying for coaching and rent, only for the Rajasthan teacher recruitment exam to be cancelled. That's why I came to Delhi. If a spark is lit here, it will spread across the country.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR